

Sharks

Top predator

Length Up to 16 ft (5 m)

Range All shallow tropical seas

Diet Fish, dolphins, and sea turtles

The reef is patrolled by sharks such as the blacktip reef shark and whitetip reef shark, as well as the much bigger, more deadly tiger shark. These top predators usually prowl the deeper waters outside the reef, but they also swim up the channels between the coral and into shallow reef lagoons.



▲ TIGER SHARK

Armed with excellent senses of sight and smell, the tiger shark is a nocturnal hunter, attacking anything that comes across its path.

Cleaner wrasse

Valet service

Length Up to 5 in (12 cm)

Range Indian and Pacific oceans

Diet Fish parasites

All fish suffer from bloodsucking parasites that attach themselves to the fish's gills and skin. They get help from small reef fish called cleaner wrasses, which pick off the parasites and eat them. The wrasses often

work inside their gills and even around the teeth of bigger fish, which never harm them—even if they normally feed on smaller fish. Here, a Hawaiian cleaner wrasse attends to one of its clients.



Reef stonefish

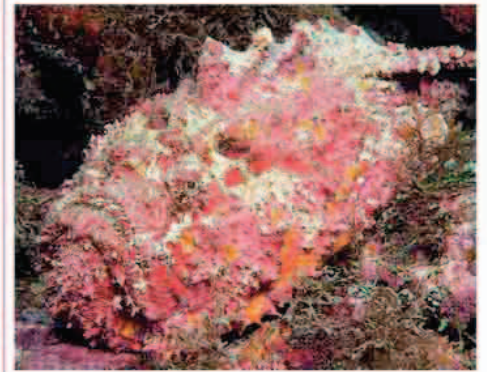
Lurking killer

Length Up to 20 in (50 cm)

Range Tropical Pacific and Indian oceans

Diet Fish and shrimp

Reef fish are often ambushed by lurking predators. They include the stonefish, camouflaged to look like a seaweed-covered rock as it lies motionless among the coral. It waits for victims to swim within range, then darts up to seize them in its gaping mouth. The stonefish is protected from its own enemies by sharp spines on its back that inject a powerful, even deadly venom.



Lionfish

Toxic spines



Length Up to 18 in (45 cm)

Range Originally Pacific and Indian oceans

Diet Small fish and other animals

The ornate fins of the lionfish conceal spines armed with a venom, making it dangerous prey for most fish. A slow-moving but skilled hunter, it relies on its bright colors to warn predators to leave it alone. As a result, the lionfish has few enemies aside from sharks and some big groupers, which seem to be immune to its stings.

